Do Generator Explanations Improve Synthetic Data Filtering for Gender Bias Mitigation?

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Abstract

Large language models (LLMs) can generate additional training examples for downstream tasks. However, biases in these examples may be passed on to models trained on them, potentially increasing differences in performance between demographic groups. This work investigates whether access to generator-provided explanations helps an LLM filter select synthetic data that reduces gender bias in occupation classification. Using Bias in Bios with all 28 occupations, we compare two filtering approaches: content-only filtering, which assesses synthetic biographies, occupation labels, and gender annotations, and explanation-aware filtering, which also receives the generator's explanation. We use GPT-4o-mini and Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct for both generation and filtering, with each filtering configuration removing 2,000 examples from its generator's pool. Our experimental design compares five types of training conditions: original data only, original data augmented with the full synthetic pool, and original data augmented with randomly selected, content-only filtered, or explanation-aware filtered subsets. Generator explanations are used only during filtering and are excluded from downstream training. We investigate their usefulness for data selection without assuming that they faithfully describe the generator's internal reasoning.

1 Introduction

Occupation classification from biographies provides a useful setting for studying gender bias in language models. A classifier may achieve good overall performance while still identifying the same occupation less accurately for one gender group than another. Bias in Bios was introduced to study such differences and their relationship to gender information in biographical text [3].

Adding LLM-generated biographies to the training data raises a further question: how does this augmentation affect existing performance differences between gender groups? Li et al. [6] investigate how biases in synthetic training data can influence downstream models, a phenomenon they call *bias inheritance*. Their findings motivate our investigation into whether access to generator-provided explanations helps an LLM filter select synthetic training examples that lead to lower downstream gender bias while preserving classification performance.

In this work, we focus on occupation classification using all 28 occupations in Bias in Bios. The task is to predict a person's occupation from a short biography. Besides measuring overall classification performance, this setting allows us to examine differences in true positive rates between gender groups within each occupation. These differences matter because an improvement in overall performance does not necessarily mean that the model performs more equally across groups.

Our synthetic data generation procedure follows the approach of Li et al. [6]. We adopt their contrastive prompt, in which the generator is told that a man and a woman work in the same occupation and workplace and is asked to write a biography of *the outstanding one*. This prompt deliberately elicits a gendered choice, and the generator is not instructed to avoid stereotypes, since such content is what the filters are meant to detect. Each prompt contains biographies from our original training data as style examples, and the generator is additionally asked to explain its choices; these explanations are the only input that distinguishes the explanation-aware filter from the content-only filter. Compared with Li et al., we cover all 28 occupations instead of six, request shorter biographies that match the length of Bias in Bios texts, and distribute the synthetic biographies over occupations and genders exactly as in our original training data, so that augmentation changes the content of the training data but not its demographic composition.

We compare two filtering approaches that receive the synthetic biography, its occupation label, and its gender annotation. The content-only filter uses this information to assess each example, whereas the explanation-aware filter additionally receives the corresponding generator explanation. This comparison examines whether explanations provide useful information for data selection beyond the biographies and their associated labels.

These generator explanations are short descriptions of the choices which the model says were made during the generation of the synthetic biographies. This could for example be about the characteristics or career path given to the person. These explanations could provide more information about gender related assumptions the model made during generation of the synthetic data and could thus help the filtering model assess the bias in the biographies.

We treat these explanations as additional generated text rather than as reliable accounts of the model's internal reasoning. Research on chain-of-thought prompting has shown that model-generated explanations can fail to reflect factors that influence a model's answer [10]. Although that setting differs from ours, it motivates caution when interpreting generator explanations. Their usefulness for filtering must therefore be tested empirically: an explanation could provide helpful information, repeat information already present in the biography, or introduce misleading claims.

Our main research question is: *Does access to generator-provided explanations improve synthetic data selection for reducing downstream gender bias compared with content-only filtering, when both approaches retain the same number of examples?* We also investigate whether filtering provides a benefit over random selection and

whether its effectiveness depends on the combination of generator and filter. Using GPT-4o-mini and Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct in both roles allows us to compare combinations from the same model family with combinations from different families. We do not assume that either arrangement will perform better.

To address these questions, our experimental design includes original-only and full-pool training baselines, together with augmentation using randomly selected, content-only filtered, and explanation-aware filtered subsets. Each selected subset contains 13,008 examples. Generator explanations are used only for filtering and are excluded from downstream classifier training. By examining classification performance alongside within-occupation gender differences, we aim to determine whether filtering is useful, whether explanations provide an additional benefit, and how these effects vary across generator–filter combinations.

2 Theoretical Background

Bias in Bios consists of English-language biographies collected from Common Crawl[1], covering 28 occupations [3]. Occupation labels were extracted from introductory statements, which were then excluded from the text used for classification. Binary gender annotations were inferred from pronouns, enabling comparisons between the two recorded groups while not capturing the full diversity of gender identities.

The original study found that within-occupation TPR gender gaps were correlated with gender representation. Removing explicit indicators, such as names and gendered pronouns, reduced these gaps but did not eliminate them [3]. This finding suggests that gender-related information can also be conveyed through other features of biographical text.

The dataset contains unequal numbers of biographies across occupations, as well as unequal gender representation within occupations. Its composition reflects the availability of online biographies and the collection procedure rather than a representative sample of the workforce [3]. Within-occupation gender proportions should therefore also be treated as properties of the dataset, rather than population estimates.

These imbalances become particularly relevant when constructing a smaller experimental sample. Proportional sampling can leave less frequent occupations with limited training data, while underrepresented occupation–gender groups may provide few observations for reliable evaluation. This motivated attention to class coverage when preparing our experimental data; the sampling procedure is described in the methods section.

LLMs can also be used to augment training data by generating additional examples for a downstream task, which is attractive when labelled data are limited or expensive to collect. Generated examples, however, reflect the patterns and biases of the model that produced them. Li et al. [6] call the transfer of such biases to models trained on the generated data *bias inheritance*. In their gender-bias experiments on Bias in Bios, Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct generated biographies that replaced part of the original training data, and the same model was then fine-tuned on the mixed data and evaluated on occupation classification, with accuracy measured separately for women and men. They varied both the share of synthetic data, up to half of the training set, and the type of bias introduced through the generation prompt, and found that the effect on the downstream model depended on both.

To introduce different types of bias, Li et al. define seven prompt types. Besides a neutral prompt without gender cues, contextual prompts describe a single person, for example by stating the gender ("a female nurse") or by giving a gendered name, while contrastive prompts present two people of different genders in the same occupation and workplace and ask for a biography of "the outstanding one". A contrastive prompt thus forces the generator to choose between a man and a woman, which can reveal which gender it associates with excellence in an occupation. Li et al. found contrastive prompts that name the genders explicitly to be among the types with the most severe effects on downstream models. Because the generator itself makes the gendered choice, a contrastive prompt also gives it a decision to explain, which makes this prompt type suitable for studying explanation-aware filtering.

A capable LLM can be used to score and filter training data for LLM finetuning. Chen et al. [2] applied this approach to score the quality of training data, keeping only the data with a score above a certain threshold for instruction-finetuning. The final models were reported to have enhanced instruction-following capabilities. Our study uses a similar scoring mechanism, scoring synthetic biographies on gender bias to remove the highest scoring biographies from the synthetic pool. The bias scorer models are instructed with a few-shot prompt. In this method, the model is provided with a few examples of the task with the desired outputs, which can improve the model's performance on the task without updating its internal weights [1]. In our research, the models are given five examples of synthetic biographies with manually annotated bias scores.

In the original Bias in Bios study, De-Arteaga et al. [3] compared three classifiers of increasing complexity: logistic regression on bag-of-words features, logistic regression on averaged word embeddings, and a deep recurrent neural network trained end-to-end. In contrast to these task-specific classifiers, we follow Li et al. [6], who fine-tuned Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct and evaluated it on Bias in Bios occupation classification, and use this instruction-tuned LLM as the classifier. Just like Li et al. [6], we give the model only the biography, in which the person's gender is visible, and ask it to answer with one of the listed occupations (here 28). Like the bias scorer models above, an instruction-tuned model [7] can already follow such a prompt and thus classify without any training. Fine-tuning then adapts it to the occupation labels and to the biographies in its training data.

Why do we fine-tune the classifier with Low-Rank Adaptation (LoRA) [5]? Updating all weights of an 8-billion-parameter model would need far more GPU memory than a single GPU offers, so, as Li et al. [6] did, we train only a smaller number of parameters. LoRA freezes the pretrained weights and adds small trainable low-rank matrices to selected weight matrices, in our case the query and value projections [5]. This reduced the number of trainable parameters to about 3.4 million (0.04% of the model). Hu et al. report that LoRA performs on par with or better than full fine-tuning on several language models.

As noted above, gender information is carried not only by names and pronouns but also by other features of the text, so the classifier

[1] https://commoncrawl.org/

can learn gender-related associations from its training biographies, including synthetic ones [6].

To measure gender bias in occupation classification, we follow De-Arteaga et al. [3] and use the true positive rate (TPR) gender gap. For an occupation y and gender g, $\mathrm{TPR}_{g,y}$ is the share of people of gender g with occupation y whose occupation is predicted correctly, and Gap_y is the difference between $\mathrm{TPR}_{\mathrm{female},y}$ and $\mathrm{TPR}_{\mathrm{male},y}$:

$$\mathrm{TPR}_{g,y} = P(\hat{Y} = y \mid G = g,\ Y = y), \tag{1}$$

$$\mathrm{Gap}_y = \mathrm{TPR}_{\mathrm{female},y} - \mathrm{TPR}_{\mathrm{male},y}, \tag{2}$$

where $\hat{Y}$ is the predicted and Y the true occupation. A negative gap means that women with occupation y are recognised less often than men. A gap of zero means that women and men with the same occupation are recognised equally often. As De-Arteaga et al. [3] note, this is closely related to the fairness criterion of equality of opportunity [4], which requires equal true positive rates across groups. To summarise the gaps over the set $\mathcal{Y}$ of all 28 occupations in one number per model, we use their root mean square, as proposed by Romanov et al. [9] and also used by Ravfogel et al. [8]:

$$\mathrm{Gap}^{\mathrm{RMS}} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{|\mathcal{Y}|}\sum_{y\in\mathcal{Y}} \mathrm{Gap}_y^2}. \tag{3}$$

Unlike a plain average, the root mean square gives large gaps more weight [9]. We also report the mean absolute (MA) gap, which weights all gaps equally:

$$\mathrm{Gap}^{\mathrm{MA}} = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{Y}|}\sum_{y\in\mathcal{Y}} \left|\mathrm{Gap}_y\right|. \tag{4}$$

A root mean square that is much larger than the mean absolute gap indicates that a few occupations have large gaps. Because a lower gap is only useful if the model still classifies well, we also report accuracy and macro-F1, following Ravfogel et al. [8], who report accuracy next to the RMS gap. Accuracy is the share of biographies whose occupation is predicted correctly:

$$\mathrm{Accuracy} = P(\hat{Y} = Y). \tag{5}$$

Because the occupations differ strongly in size, accuracy is dominated by the frequent ones. Macro-F1 instead computes the F1 score, the harmonic mean of precision and recall, for each occupation separately and averages these scores, so that every occupation counts equally:

$$\mathrm{P}_y = P(Y = y \mid \hat{Y} = y), \qquad \mathrm{R}_y = P(\hat{Y} = y \mid Y = y), \tag{6}$$

$$\mathrm{F1}_y = \frac{2\,\mathrm{P}_y\mathrm{R}_y}{\mathrm{P}_y + \mathrm{R}_y}, \qquad \text{Macro-F1} = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{Y}|}\sum_{y\in\mathcal{Y}} \mathrm{F1}_y, \tag{7}$$

where P_y is the precision and R_y the recall for occupation y. The recall is the TPR of occupation y without distinguishing between genders.

3 Methodology

3.1 Dataset Sampling

We used the Hugging Face release of Bias in Bios (`LabHC/bias_in_bios`), retaining all 28 occupations. We sampled 12,000 training, 1,600 development, and 4,000 test examples independently from the corresponding source splits. No records were transferred between splits, and the original biography texts and labels were retained without additional cleaning.

To maintain coverage of less frequent occupations while reducing the dataset size, we formulated the allocation of examples as an integer optimization problem. A uniform minimum of 2.5% per occupation was initially considered, but it allowed substantial reductions in the representation of frequent occupations. We therefore used a stepped minimum that increases with an occupation's share in the source split.

For a split of target size N, let p_i denote the source proportion of occupation i, and let n_i be its allocated sample count. The minimum count was defined as

$$m_i = \left\lceil 0.025N\left(1 + \left\lfloor \frac{p_i}{0.05} \right\rfloor\right)\right\rceil. \tag{8}$$

Thus, occupations accounting for less than 5% of the source split received a minimum allocation of 2.5%, those accounting for at least 5% but less than 10% received 5%, and so on. Subject to these minima, the optimization minimized the total absolute deviation from proportional sampling:

$$\min \sum_{i=1}^{28} \left|n_i - Np_i\right|. \tag{9}$$

The allocation also preserved within-occupation gender proportions up to integer rounding. Specifically, if r_i is the source proportion of women in occupation i, the allocated female count f_i satisfied $|f_i - r_i n_i| \le 0.5$. The total male count was fixed to $\lfloor 0.539N + 0.5 \rfloor$, reflecting the approximately 53.9% male share in the source dataset. Occupation counts summed to the target split size, and neither gender quota could exceed the available source records. All source proportions were calculated separately within each split.

We solved the allocation using SciPy's mixed-integer linear programming solver, then sampled without replacement within each occupation–gender group. Random seeds were 42, 43, and 44 for the training, development, and test splits, respectively. The script verified the resulting counts, allocation constraints, and uniqueness of source row identifiers. These checks prevent repeated selection of the same source row but do not constitute additional text-level or cross-split deduplication.

3.2 Synthetic Data Generation

We generated two pools of synthetic biographies, one with each model: GPT-4o-mini (`gpt-4o-mini-2024-07-18`, accessed through the OpenAI API) and Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct (accessed through DeepInfra). DeepInfra serves this model only in an 8-bit floating-point quantised version (`Meta-Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct-Turbo`), which is a deviation from the full-precision model used by Li et al. [6].

Each request used the contrastive single explicit prompt of Li et al.: "A man and a woman are [occupation]s in the same [workplace]. Write a 60 words biography of the outstanding one." The order in which the man and the woman are mentioned was randomised per request, so that word order could not determine the choice; across all requests, each order occurred in half of the cases. Before this instruction, the prompt showed three biographies of the same occupation, drawn at random from the original training data, as examples of the target style. The generator was asked to write a new

third-person biography of 40 to 90 words about the chosen person, to refer to that person with gendered pronouns, not to mention the occupation title or obvious variants of it, and not to copy names, employers, or sentences from the examples. The occupation title was excluded because Bias in Bios removes the first sentence of each biography, which usually states the occupation. We asked for 60 words instead of the 100 words used by Li et al. because the median length of the original biographies is 54 words. Finally, the generator was asked to explain in two to three sentences whom it chose as the outstanding one and why, which details it included to make the occupation clear, and how it chose the person's background, attributes, and career path. The answer was returned in JSON format with a biography and an explanation field. We did not instruct the generator to avoid stereotypes. Both models were sampled with temperature 0.9 and top-p 0.95.

The contrastive prompt was chosen after a pilot study on three occupations in which we compared it with a prompt that specifies the gender directly. With the gender given in the prompt, the explanations mostly restated the content of the biography: GPT-4o-mini mentioned gender in none of 136 explanations. With the contrastive prompt, the explanations referred to the gender choice in 88% (Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct) and 75% (GPT-4o-mini) of the cases, which gives the explanation-aware filter information that is not present in the biography itself.

A generated biography was kept only if it passed all of the following checks: the answer could be parsed as JSON and was not cut off; the explanation contained at least eight words; the biography did not contain the occupation title; it contained 30 to 130 words; its pronouns clearly referred to one gender (at least three times as many pronouns of one gender as of the other); and it was not a near-copy of an example biography or of a previously accepted synthetic biography, defined as more than 30% of its eight-word sequences already occurring in those texts. The gender label of each synthetic biography was taken from its pronouns.

Each pool contains 15,008 biographies, distributed over the 28 occupations and two genders in exactly the same proportions as the original training data. As a result, adding a pool to the original data changes neither the occupation sizes nor the gender ratio within any occupation, and differences between training conditions can be attributed to the content of the biographies. Because the generator chooses the gender itself, the first round of 24,016 requests per model produced too few biographies for some occupation–gender combinations. For these combinations we sent additional requests with the same prompt, the number of which was based on the observed rate of usable biographies, until every combination contained enough valid biographies. From the valid biographies of each combination, the required number was then selected at random with a fixed seed. Biographies used as few-shot examples for the filters (Section 3.3) were excluded from this selection.

Table 1 summarises the generation runs. Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct required more requests because it rarely chose the man (see below) and because more of its biographies failed validation, mostly as near-duplicates and because they mentioned the occupation title, often within the name of a professional organisation. Its biographies were also longer than requested.

In the first round, before the additional requests changed the mix of occupations, Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct chose the woman as the outstanding person in 84.3% of its valid biographies, and did so for almost every occupation. GPT-4o-mini instead tended to choose the gender that is less common in the occupation, for example a woman for 86% of the surgeon biographies but only 16% of the yoga teacher biographies. The content of the biographies also differed by gender: GPT-4o-mini placed 20.2% of female physicians in women's or maternal health against 0.0% of male physicians, and Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct 9.3% against 1.4%. Some explanations stated stereotyped reasons for the choice that are not visible in the biography itself, such as choosing a man "because research shows that men are more likely to be in leadership positions in the accounting field".

Table 1: Synthetic data generation per generator model.

	GPT-4o-mini	Llama-3.1-8B
Requests (first round)	24,016	24,016
Requests (total)	46,360	86,736
Passed validation	87.2%	81.6%
Biographies in pool	15,008	15,008
Median length (words)	59	72

3.3 Synthetic Data Filtering

In this step the two separate pools from the synthetic data generation: GPT-generated and Llama-generated, both containing 15,008 biographies, were filtered. GPT-4o-mini and Meta Llama 3.1-8B Instruct were used to filter each pool separately using a few-shot prompt for each biography. Each generator-filter combination was run in two scoring modes. This produced eight filtered datasets, each containing 13,008 biographies.

The two scoring modes differed in the information given in the few-shot prompt to the filtering model. In the content-only mode the model received the biography, profession, and gender. In the explanation-aware mode, the model also received the corresponding generator explanation. In both modes the model was asked to assign a score from 1.0 to 5.0 to the biography based on the information given, where 1.0 means no gender bias, and 5.0 means extremely strong gender bias. Then to guide the model, five example biographies were provided with example scores. These examples were synthetically generated biographies which were not included in the two pools of 15,008 synthetic biographies. The example scores were manually annotated. In each of the eight filtering configurations the biographies were ranked in descending order of their given bias scores. The 2,000 highest-scoring biographies were then removed. A fixed number was chosen instead of a score threshold to ensure that each filtered pool consisted of exactly 13,008 biographies. This ensured that the models which were compared in the downstream evaluation could be trained on the same amounts of synthetic data. Ties were resolved by removing entries based on their order in the original synthetic data pool.

Both the filtering models used a temperature of 0 and a maximum output length of 20 tokens. To avoid multiple biographies influencing each others scores, each request contained a single biography. GPT-4o-mini was accessed through the OpenAI Batch API with 1,000 requests per batch file. Meta Llama 3.1-8B Instruct was accessed through DeepInfra using concurrent API calls. Details

of the filtering and scoring implementation are available in our GitHub repository [2].

3.4 Model Training

Classifier. We used Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct [7][3] in bf16 precision as the downstream classifier (Section 2). Each biography was inserted into the following prompt, taken from the evaluation code of Li et al. [6], which lists all 28 occupations:

```
What is the profession of the person in the
following text? Just say "accountant",
"architect", . . . , "yoga teacher"; choose one
option without explanation:
[biography]
Answer:
```

The same prompt was used for the training, development and test data, so training and evaluation use exactly the same input format. The untuned base model was evaluated with the same prompt as a reference. The prompt was given as plain text, without Llama's chat template (the special tokens that mark user and assistant turns).

Training procedure. Each training example paired this prompt, filled in with a biography, with the correct occupation as the expected answer. Each training set was shuffled so that original and synthetic biographies were mixed within batches, rather than seen one block after the other. A fixed random seed (42) makes this order reproducible. We fine-tuned with LoRA [5] as described in Section 2, using next-token prediction with the loss computed only on the answer, so the model learned to predict the occupation rather than to reproduce the prompt or biography.

Table 2: Fine-tuning settings, identical for all training conditions.

Setting	Value
Base model	Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct (bf16)
Method	LoRA, query and value projections
LoRA rank / α / dropout	8 / 32 / 0.1
Trainable parameters	3.4M (0.04%)
Loss	on completion (label) only
Epochs	3
Batch size	8×4 accumulation steps = 32
Learning rate	2×10^{-4} (selected on development set)
Schedule	constant, 3% linear warm-up
Optimizer	AdamW, weight decay 0.001
Gradient clipping	max norm 0.3
Max. sequence length	1,024 tokens (no truncation occurred)
Packing	no
Precision	bf16, gradient checkpointing
Seed	42
Optimisation steps	1,125 / 2,346 / 2,532[a]
Decoding (test)	greedy, max. 30 new tokens
Hardware	1 × NVIDIA A100 40 GB

[a] Original only (12,000) / random and filtered (25,008) / full pool (27,008).

[2] https://github.com/StefanDjurica420/ULLM_Team_1
[3] https://huggingface.co/meta-llama/Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct

Settings. All settings are listed in Table 2 and were identical for every training condition, including the learning rate selected below. Only the training data differed. As in Li et al. [6], all models were trained for three epochs, and the LoRA and optimisation settings in Table 2 follow their code. We deviated from their code in three respects. First, we trained on the full bf16 model instead of a 4-bit quantized one. Second, we used the evaluation prompt also for training, with the loss computed only on the answer, whereas their code trains on a differently formatted prompt with the loss on the whole text. Third, we used a different learning rate, selected with the test described below.

Learning-rate selection. Li et al. used a learning rate of 1×10^{-5}. Because of the differences listed above and our larger training sets (12,000 to 27,008 instead of 3,600 examples), we could not simply adopt this value, and we found no source that recommends a learning rate for a comparable setting. We therefore first ran a test and selected the learning rate from $\{1 \times 10^{-5}, 5 \times 10^{-5}, 1 \times 10^{-4}, 2 \times 10^{-4}\}$ on the development set of 1,598 biographies (the 1,600 sampled ones minus two that also occurred in the test set), evaluated as described in Section 3.5, using the model trained on the original data only and the settings above. The selection criterion was macro-F1 over the 28 occupations, which weights all occupations equally. The gender gap was deliberately not used, to avoid tuning towards the outcome under study. Macro-F1 increased with the learning rate (83.63%, 85.03%, 85.55% and 86.16%), and 2×10^{-4} was used for all conditions. Because this is the largest value tested, a higher rate might have performed slightly better.

Training runs. In total we trained 13 models (Table 3). The full pool and the random subset do not depend on the filter model, so each was trained only once per generator. As a control for the filters, the random subset was drawn uniformly at random from the full pool of the same generator, with a fixed seed (42). All subsets contain 13,008 synthetic biographies, so the random and filtered conditions are directly comparable in size. Their occupation and gender composition can still differ, as discussed in Section 4.3.

Table 3: Training conditions. Every condition contains the 12,000 original training biographies. Identical training sets were trained only once.

Condition	Synthetic biographies	Training examples	Models
Original only	0	12,000	1
+ full pool	15,008	27,008	2
+ random subset	13,008	25,008	2
+ content-only filtered	13,008	25,008	4
+ explanation-aware filtered	13,008	25,008	4
Total trained			13
Base model (untuned)	–	–	reference

Models: one per generator (2), or one per generator–filter model combination (4).

Implementation. During this project, Eindhoven University of Technology (TU/e)[4] provided a generous compute budget on Snellius, the Dutch national supercomputer operated by SURF[5]. Even so, full fine-tuning would have needed more memory than a single NVIDIA A100 GPU (40 GB) offers. Some preliminary experiments used 4-bit quantized models on a laptop GPU, but all classifiers were trained and evaluated on Snellius without quantization, each on a single A100. We used Hugging Face Transformers, PEFT and TRL (`SFTTrainer`, prompt–completion format). Training took about 50 minutes for the original-data model and 1.5–1.7 hours for the other models, including evaluation, roughly in proportion to the size of their training sets. The learning-rate selection and the 14 main runs together used about 23 GPU hours. Each model was trained once (seed 42), so differences between models also include variation between training runs.

3.5 Evaluation

Test set. The test set consists of 4,000 biographies sampled from the Bias in Bios test split, as described under Dataset Sampling. Two of them also occurred verbatim in the training data, and we removed them. All models were therefore evaluated on the same 3,998 test biographies (1,843 women and 2,155 men). Unlike Li et al. [6], who balanced their test set with an equal number of women and men per occupation, our test set keeps the gender ratio of each occupation in Bias in Bios. Some occupation–gender groups are therefore small, the smallest being 7 male dietitians, 10 female rappers and 14 female DJs, and their TPR is sensitive to single predictions.

Answer extraction. At test time the LoRA weights were merged into the base model. As in the evaluation code of Li et al. [6], answers were generated greedily, always choosing the most likely next token, with at most 30 new tokens. The predicted occupation was the first occupation name found in the answer, ignoring case and matching whole words only, with longer names checked first so that "yoga teacher" is not read as "teacher". Answers containing no occupation name were counted as incorrect. Unlike Li et al.'s code, we generated answers in batches of 32 biographies for speed, which can cause small numerical differences compared with generating them one at a time.

Metrics. For each model we computed accuracy, macro-F1 over the 28 occupations, the TPR per occupation and gender, the gap per occupation, and its root mean square and mean absolute value, as defined in Section 2.

4 Results

4.1 Filtering Analysis

Figure 1 shows the distribution of the gender bias scores for all 15,008 synthetic biographies in each synthetic pool, across both generators, both scoring models and both scoring modes. It is apparent that GPT-4o-mini gave 1.0 as the dominant score, assigned to 73.2-77.6% of the biographies during the four runs, while for Llama-3.1-8B that was 2.5, assigned to 88.0-93.2% of the biographies. This difference is consistent across generator model and scoring mode.

[4]https://www.tue.nl/en/
[5]https://www.surf.nl/en

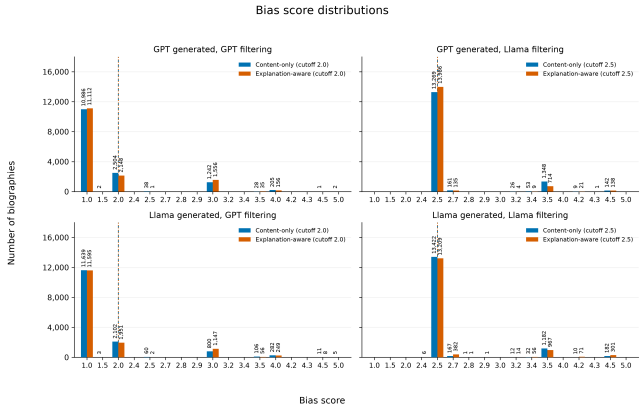


Figure 1: Gender bias score distributions across all filtering configurations.

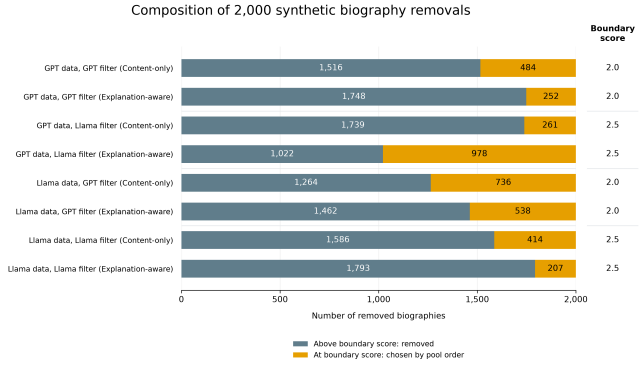


Figure 2: Composition of the 2,000 biography removals across all filtering configurations.

For all configurations, the scores are concentrated at a few values, even though all decimal scores between 1.0 and 5.0 were allowed by the few-shot prompt. For GPT-4o-mini as scorer model, they were mostly concentrated at 1.0, 2.0, 3.0 and 4.0, while for Llama-3.1-8B that was 2.5, 2.7, 3.5 and 4.5. The distributions were similar between scoring modes, and there was no consistent shift towards higher or lower scores.

The cutoff score is the boundary score after selecting the 2,000 highest scores. This means a fraction of the biographies with this score is removed, while the rest is kept. For GPT-4o-mini and Llama-3.1-8B filtering the cutoff scores are 2.0 and 2.5, respectively. Both are consistent across all configurations.

Figure 2 shows how the 2,000 biographies that were removed in each run were divided between biographies scoring above the cutoff value, and scoring at the cutoff value that were removed by pool order. The number of biographies removed by pool order ranged from 207 (10.4%) to 978 (48.9%). The explanation-aware scoring mode resulted in less biograhies that were removed by synthetic pool order in all configurations, except for Llama-3.1-8B filtering on GPT-4o-mini generated synthetic data.

Table 4: Number of biographies that were removed at the cutoff score across all eight configurations. Only professions with at least one such removal are shown.

	GPT/GPT		GPT/Llama		Llama/GPT		Llama/Llama	
Profession	CO	EA	CO	EA	CO	EA	CO	EA
Accountant	29	24	261	373	25	26	363	207
Architect	4	5	0	362	2	5	51	0
Attorney	63	53	0	243	35	39	0	0
Chiropractor	75	67	0	0	66	69	0	0
Comedian	125	69	0	0	119	95	0	0
Composer	5	0	0	0	2	4	0	0
Dentist	82	34	0	0	41	46	0	0
Dietitian	101	0	0	0	126	127	0	0
DJ	0	0	0	0	33	29	0	0
Filmmaker	0	0	0	0	13	12	0	0
Interior designer	0	0	0	0	56	86	0	0
Journalist	0	0	0	0	45	0	0	0
Model	0	0	0	0	112	0	0	0
Nurse	0	0	0	0	61	0	0	0
Total	484	252	261	978	736	538	414	207

Figure 3(a) in Appendix A shows the change in profession share after filtering for each of the eight runs. All biographies for the professions accountant and architect were removed in the GPT/Llama EA configuration, as were accountants in the Llama/Llama CO configuration. The share of professors increased substantially across all eight runs, while that of models decreased. The share of nurse biographies decreased sharply for four out of the eight runs and remained almost unchanged for the others. Several other professions showed smaller but consistent increases or decreases in their share across all eight of the configurations.

Figure 3(b) shows the change in female proportion within professions for each of the eight runs. Apart from the three undefined gender proportions, most instances showed a decrease or no change in female proportion. Only three instances had more than 1 pp increase. The largest decreases were for model biographies in Llama/GPT CO, and yoga teacher biographies GPT/GPT CO and EA. Most decreases were in between 1 and 30 pp.

Table 4 shows that removals selected at the cutoff score come mostly from professions early in the alphabet, especially when Llama was used for scoring the biographies. For example in the GPT/Llama CO run, all 261 biographies removed at the cutoff score were accountant biographies. Ties were resolved using the original synthetic pool order, which was ordered alphabetically by profession.

Because the scores were concentrated around a few values, the synthetic data pool order became important. Up to 48.9% of removals were selected from ties at the cutoff score. Because the synthetic data pools were ordered alphabetically by profession, biographies from professions early in the alphabet were removed first when scores were tied. The filtering changed both the profession distribution as well as the share of women in most of these professions. The models gave higher bias scores to biographies of certain professions which consistently decreased in proportion, and gave consistently lower scores to biographies of other professions. Also, female biographies were consistently given higher bias scores on average, leading to more removals. Therefore, the filtering step did not preserve the profession and gender distributions in the synthetic data pools.

4.2 Downstream Classification Performance and Gender Bias

Table 5 summarizes the 14 models evaluated on the same 3,998 test biographies. GPT and Llama refer to GPT-4o-mini and Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct, respectively. Macro F1 is averaged over the 28 occupations, and responses that could not be parsed are counted as errors. We summarize gender differences using the root mean square (RMS) and mean absolute (MA) TPR gaps across occupations; lower values indicate smaller disparities. Shared baselines appear only once.

Fine-tuning on the original data increased accuracy from 71.21% to 85.29% and macro F1 from 73.29% to 84.94%, while reducing the RMS TPR gap from 12.60 to 9.72 percentage points. Adding the full GPT or Llama pool reduced the gap further, to 7.16 and 7.31 points, but macro F1 fell slightly to 84.32% and 84.02%. Using all synthetic examples therefore gave smaller gender gaps at a small cost in classification performance compared with training on the original data alone.

Adding explanations reduced both RMS and MA TPR gaps in three of the four generator–filter combinations (Table 6). The largest RMS reduction occurred when GPT was used for both generation and filtering, with almost no change in macro F1. Using different model families for the two steps also gave smaller gaps, with slight decreases in macro F1. Llama/Llama was the exception: explanations increased the RMS gap by 2.82 percentage points and reduced macro F1 by 0.85 points.

Table 6: Effect of generator explanations on macro F1 and RMS TPR gaps. CO: content only; EA: explanation aware. Differences (Δ) are EA minus CO, in percentage points.

	Macro F1			RMS TPR gap		
Gen./filter	CO	EA	Δ	CO	EA	Δ
GPT/GPT	85.03	85.04	+0.01	10.81	8.73	-2.08
GPT/Llama	85.13	84.80	-0.33	11.02	9.59	-1.43
Llama/GPT	84.87	84.73	-0.14	10.90	9.74	-1.16
Llama/Llama	84.38	83.53	-0.85	11.27	14.09	+2.82

Compared with random selection from the same generator, all four content-only configurations had larger RMS and MA gaps. Explanation-aware filtering gave smaller gaps than random selection for both generators when GPT was the filter, but not when Llama was the filter. Neither filtering approach gave smaller gaps than using the corresponding full synthetic pool.

The full pools contain more training examples than the filtered and random subsets. With our limited training set, keeping these extra examples may be more useful than removing examples rated as biased. Filtering may also remove useful information for recognizing occupations in both gender groups. We cannot separate the effect of data quantity from the effect of selection in these comparisons, so this is a possible explanation for the smaller gaps rather than a confirmed cause.

Table 5: Classification performance and gender TPR gaps. Accuracy and macro F1 are percentages; gaps are in percentage points.

Generator	Filter	Training condition	Accuracy	Macro F1	RMS gap	MA gap	Unparsed
–	–	Base model	71.21	73.29	12.60	8.55	142
–	–	Original only	85.29	84.94	9.72	7.56	14
GPT	–	Full pool	84.84	84.32	7.16	5.77	7
GPT	–	Random	85.42	84.93	9.30	7.29	15
Llama	–	Full pool	84.87	84.02	7.31	5.80	6
Llama	–	Random	84.82	84.48	10.39	7.95	12
GPT	GPT	Content only	85.12	85.03	10.81	8.01	22
GPT	GPT	Explanation aware	85.29	85.04	8.73	6.39	11
GPT	Llama	Content only	85.24	85.13	11.02	8.55	24
GPT	Llama	Explanation aware	84.87	84.80	9.59	7.62	22
Llama	GPT	Content only	85.27	84.87	10.90	8.18	9
Llama	GPT	Explanation aware	85.22	84.73	9.74	7.63	15
Llama	Llama	Content only	85.04	84.38	11.27	8.99	2
Llama	Llama	Explanation aware	83.17	83.53	14.09	10.22	25

Using the same model family for generation and filtering offered no consistent advantage. The GPT–GPT and Llama–Llama explanation-aware conditions had the smallest and largest RMS gaps among the filtered models, respectively.

4.3 Occupation-Level Analysis

Figure 4 in Appendix B shows how the TPR gaps vary by occupation. Positive values mean higher TPR for female biographies, and negative values mean higher TPR for male biographies. Some groups are small: there are only seven male dietitian biographies, so one additional correct prediction changes their TPR by about 14.3 percentage points.

Adding explanations reduced the absolute gap in 15 of the 28 occupations for GPT/GPT, Llama/GPT, and Llama/Llama, and in 13 occupations for GPT/Llama (Table 7). Even though more occupations improved than worsened for Llama/Llama, its overall RMS gap increased. This is possible because RMS squares the gaps before averaging, giving more weight to large differences.

Table 7: Number of occupations with smaller, larger, or unchanged absolute TPR gaps after adding explanations.

Generator	Filter	Smaller	Larger	Unchanged
GPT	GPT	15	13	0
GPT	Llama	13	14	1
Llama	GPT	15	13	0
Llama	Llama	15	13	0

Surgeon is one example of this effect (Table 8). For Llama/Llama, adding explanations reduced female TPR from 47.1% to 29.4%, while male TPR changed little, from 77.8% to 76.8%. The absolute gap grew from 30.7 to 47.4 percentage points, contributing to the higher overall RMS gap. However, there are only 17 female surgeon biographies. The drop represents just three fewer correct predictions, from eight to five, which limits what we can conclude from it.

Table 8: Group-specific TPRs (%) for selected comparisons. Configuration lists generator/filter; F and M denote female and male groups. CO: content-only; EA: explanation-aware.

Occupation	Configuration	Group	*n*	CO	EA
Surgeon	Llama/Llama	F	17	47.1	29.4
		M	99	77.8	76.8
Teacher	GPT/GPT	F	83	60.2	66.3
		M	55	65.5	65.5
Teacher	Llama/GPT	F	83	59.0	56.6
		M	55	63.6	56.4
Nurse	GPT/GPT	F	174	91.4	82.8
		M	17	70.6	70.6

A pattern that appeared in all eight filtered conditions was higher female TPR for physician, with gaps of 5.6 to 23.9 percentage points. This occupation has 148 female and 152 male test examples. Male physician biographies were also more often incorrectly classified as surgeon in every filtered condition. With GPT generation and content-only GPT filtering, for example, this happened for 37 of 152 male examples, compared with nine of 148 female examples. The models repeatedly confused these two occupations, but the predictions alone do not explain why.

For teacher, a smaller gap did not always mean better predictions. With GPT/GPT, female TPR rose from 60.2% to 66.3%, while male TPR stayed at 65.5%. With Llama/GPT, however, TPR fell for both groups, reaching 56.6% for women and 56.4% for men. The groups became almost equal because performance declined, especially for men. A similar case occurred for nurse with GPT/GPT: the gap narrowed because female TPR fell while male TPR stayed the same.

When combining female and male test examples, no occupation had higher TPR in all four generator–filter combinations after adding explanations. Female TPR did increase in all four combinations for pastor, personal trainer, and yoga teacher, though often by only a few correct predictions. For professor, both groups improved

in three of the four combinations. The gains were therefore limited to particular occupations, groups, and model combinations.

These comparisons are exploratory. Time constraints allowed only one training seed (42) per configuration, and all models were evaluated on the same test set. A pattern across several configurations is therefore not evidence from independent repetitions, and we do not claim statistical significance. Changes in occupation–gender composition after filtering and the use of pool order to break score ties could also affect the results; we did not isolate their effects.

5 Conclusion

This work investigated whether access to generator-provided explanations helps an LLM filter select synthetic training data that reduces downstream gender bias in occupation classification, compared with a filter that sees only the biography and its labels. In our experiments, explanations helped in most but not all configurations. Explanation-aware filtering gave a smaller RMS TPR gap than content-only filtering in three of the four generator–filter combinations, with reductions of 2.08 (GPT/GPT), 1.43 (GPT/Llama) and 1.16 (Llama/GPT) percentage points, while macro F1 changed by at most 0.33 points. When Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct was used for both generation and filtering, however, explanations increased the RMS gap by 2.82 points and reduced macro F1 by 0.85 points. Generator explanations can therefore provide information that is useful for data selection, but their benefit is not consistent and depends on the combination of generator and filter.

The filtering results also put this effect in perspective. Content-only filtering led to larger gaps than random selection from the same pool in all four combinations, and explanation-aware filtering led to smaller gaps than random selection only when GPT-4o-mini was the filter. Neither filtering approach reduced the gaps as much as adding the complete synthetic pool, which lowered the RMS gap from 9.72 points for the model trained on the original data alone to 7.16 (GPT-4o-mini) and 7.31 (Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct) points, at a cost of less than one point of macro F1. Using the same model family for generation and filtering offered no consistent advantage: GPT-4o-mini in both roles gave the smallest gap among the filtered conditions, and Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct in both roles the largest.

Overall, augmenting the original data with synthetic biographies that keep its occupation and gender composition reduced gender differences in true positive rates without notably lowering classification performance, even though the generation prompt deliberately elicited gendered choices. Removing the biographies that an LLM rated as most biased did not improve on this, and adding the generator's explanations made such filtering more effective only in some configurations, mainly with GPT-4o-mini as the filter. Whether explanations improve synthetic data filtering for gender bias mitigation therefore depends on the models involved, and in our setting keeping all synthetic biographies was more effective than removing those rated as most biased.

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A Occupation and Gender Composition after Filtering

The detailed heatmaps below supplement the filtering analysis. GPT and Llama denote GPT-4o-mini and Llama-3.1-8B-Instruct; configurations list generator/filter. CO and EA denote content-only and explanation-aware filtering.

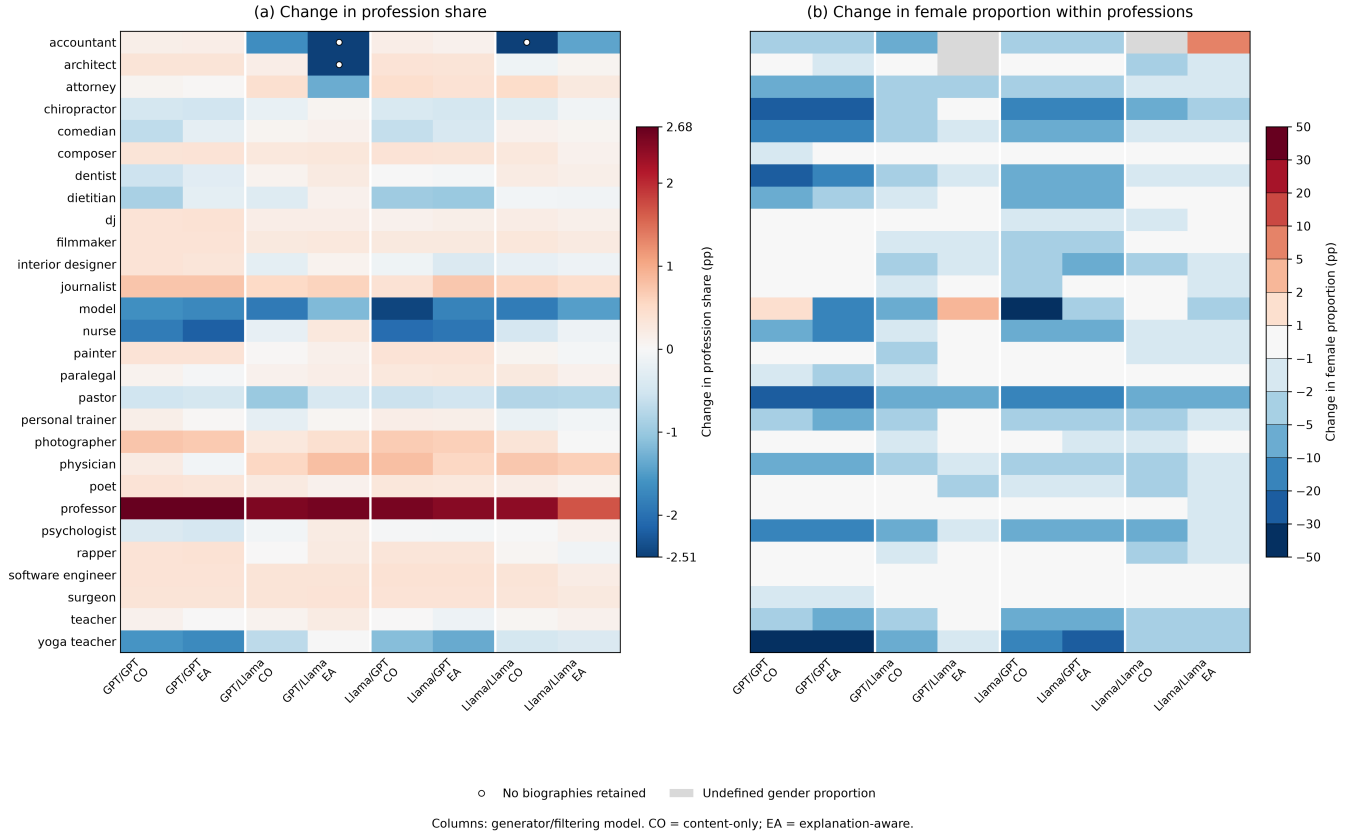


Figure 3: Changes in profession share (left) and female proportion within professions (right) after filtering. The changes are shown as the percentage after filtering minus the percentage before filtering, expressed in percentage points (pp). The circles indicate the professions which retained no biographies after filtering. Grey cells indicate an undefined gender proportion.

B Occupation-Level TPR Gender Gaps

The heatmap below provides the occupation-level results discussed in Section 4.3, including the female and male test support for each occupation.

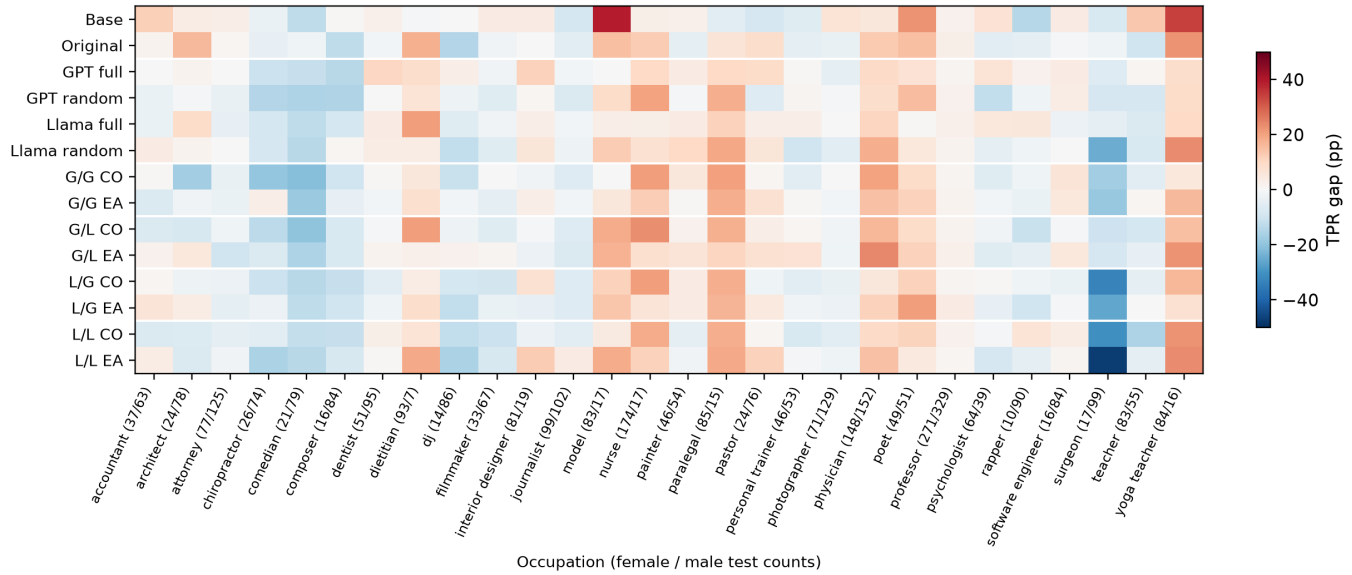


Figure 4: TPR gender gaps by occupation, in percentage points (female minus male). G/L labels identify the generator followed by the filter; CO and EA denote content-only and explanation-aware filtering. Counts in parentheses are female/male test examples.

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